

Narrative Crossroads: The Most Dangerous Game

A character analysis framework for exploring key decisions and motivations

Overview

This module adapts the Narrative Crossroads framework for analyzing Richard Connell’s “The Most Dangerous Game.” Students will roleplay as either Rainsford or General Zaroff at critical moments in the story, exploring character motivations through structured interview questions and decision points.

Setting Context

- **Time Period:** Early 20th century
- **Location:** Ship-Trap Island in the Caribbean
- **Social Context:** Post-World War I era, colonial mindset, big game hunting culture
- **Atmosphere:** Isolated, threatening, primordial

Character Options

Roll 1d10 or choose.

Roll	Character	Confrontation	Comprehension	Connection
1-5	Rainsford	70%	60%	50%
6-10	General Zaroff	60%	70%	65%

Threshold Moments

Roll 1d10 or choose.

Roll	Threshold Moment	Decision Points (with Required Skills)
1-3	Falling overboard	1. Surviving the swim to shore (Confrontation) 2. Deciding whether to call out upon seeing lights (Connection)
4-6	Discovering Zaroff hunts humans	1. Recognizing Zaroff’s hidden meaning (Comprehension) 2. Deciding how to respond (Connection)
7-10	Being hunted	1. Creating traps and defenses (Confrontation) 2. Anticipating Zaroff’s strategy (Comprehension)

Confrontation Questions

Roll 1d10.

Roll	Question
1	How do you prepare for dangerous situations?
2	What hunting technique are you most proud of?
3	When have you been most afraid during a hunt?
4	How do you respond to direct threats?
5	What gives you an edge over your opponents?
6	What physical challenge has tested you most?
7	How do you maintain control in chaotic situations?
8	What risk have you taken that others would consider foolish?

9	How do you handle being physically outmatched?
10	What tactics do you use when outmaneuvered?

Comprehension Questions

Roll 1d10.

Roll	Question
1	How do you analyze an unfamiliar environment?
2	What insights have you gained from your hunting experiences?
3	How do you determine a worthy adversary?
4	What patterns do you look for when tracking prey?
5	What philosophical perspective guides your decisions?
6	How do you use your environment to your advantage?
7	What bores you intellectually?
8	What does fear teach you about yourself or others?
9	What separates humans from animals in your view?
10	How do you distinguish between instinct and reason?

Connection Questions

Roll 1d10.

Roll	Question
1	What do you enjoy outside of hunting?
2	How do you treat those you consider beneath you?
3	What frustrates you about other people?
4	How do you build trust with strangers?
5	What disappoints you about your fellow man?
6	How do you view those who don't share your values?
7	What code of conduct do you follow?
8	What do you think of your prey?
9	What motivates you beyond survival or sport?
10	How would you like to be remembered?

Thematic Elements

- The hunter versus the hunted
- Civilization versus savagery
- The value of human life
- The ethics of sport and hunting
- Predator and prey psychology

Implementation Guide

Classroom Setup (45-60 minutes)

1. **Introduction (5 min):** Explain the Narrative Crossroads system and distribute materials
2. **Character Selection (5 min):** Students roll or choose their character

3. **Threshold Moment (5 min):** Students roll or select their threshold moment
4. **Character Interview (15-20 min):** Students roll for and answer their three questions
5. **Decision Resolution (10 min):** Students roll for and describe key decision outcomes
6. **Reflection (10-15 min):** Students document insights and connections to themes

Materials Needed

- Two ten-sided dice (d10). Roll one for selection; roll both as tens and units for skill checks. A dice-rolling app works equally well.
- Character sheets
- Journal sheets for responses
- Copy of “The Most Dangerous Game”

Assessment Options

- **Character Journal:** Students submit written responses from the character’s perspective
- **Audio Character Study:** Students record their interview responses as the character
- **Comparative Analysis:** Students compare their character’s decisions with others
- **Alternate Ending:** Based on different decision outcomes, students craft alternative endings

ELA Standards Alignment

- **RL.9-10.1** — Cite strong and thorough textual evidence to support analysis
- **RL.9-10.3** — Analyze how complex characters develop, interact with other characters, and advance the plot
- **W.9-10.3** — Write narratives with well-developed characters and event sequences
- **SL.9-10.1** — Initiate and participate effectively in collaborative discussions

Sample Play: Rainsford Being Hunted

Character: Rainsford **Skills:** Confrontation 70%, Comprehension 60%, Connection 50%

Threshold Moment: Being hunted — the moment when Rainsford must decide how to counter Zaroff’s pursuit.

Decision Point: Rainsford must create an effective trap to slow Zaroff’s pursuit.

Required Skill: Confrontation 70%

Dice Roll: 42 against Confrontation 70% = Success

Outcome: “Drawing on your extensive hunting experience, you construct a Malay man-catcher—a weighted log attached to a trigger. The work is precise and methodical despite your exhaustion and the growing darkness. Each time you hear distant sounds of pursuit, your hands work faster, but you maintain the careful attention to detail that has kept you alive on countless hunts. As you put the finishing touches on the trap, you allow yourself a moment of grim satisfaction. You’ve transformed from hunted to hunter, setting the stage for your pursuer to become the pursued. The trap isn’t just a physical defense; it’s a psychological statement—evidence that Zaroff has finally found the worthy prey he so desperately sought.”

Version 2

This product is licensed under the ORC License held in the Library of Congress at TX-307-067 and available online at various locations including www.chaosium.com/orclicense.

This product is the original work of Geoffrey Sperl.

BRP and Basic Roleplaying are trademarks of Chaosium Inc.